CONSUMING FIRE
MINISTRIES INTERNATIONAL

GUIDELINES

FOR DEACONS AND DEACONESSES

Introduction

This manual will help the Church to understand the role and office of deacons and deaconesses. Deacons(esses) are qualified, tested, and authorized men/women who serve the church as officers by performing tasks assigned by the elders or pastors. The word "deacon" (diakonos) and its related terms "to deacon" (diakoneo) and "deacon-ship" (diakonia) is commonly translated "servant" ("to serve," "service") and "minister" ("to minister," "ministry") respectively. Deacons and deaconesses are concerned with the material needs of the congregation. The ministry of deacons was introduced to the Church in Acts 6. In Acts 6, the apostles faced accusations of neglect and favouritism within the Jerusalem church, and thye directed the disciples to choose "seven men of good repute, full of the Spirit and of wisdom" for the daily distribution. From this we learn that the tasks of deacons should be those requiring a Spirit-filled, qualified, tested, and authorized servant. The word deacon comes out more vividly in Philippians 1:1 and 1 Timothy 3:8-13. The Bible shows us that deacons and deaconesses are not rulers but servant-leaders working within the church to assist the elders in the ministry. Therefore, those who serve in this office will serve under the oversight of an elder in their appropriate segment of ministry.

"Paul and Timothy, servants of Christ Jesus, To all the saints in Christ Jesus who are at Philippi, with the overseers and **deacons**." (Php 1:1).

"Deacons likewise must be dignified, not double-tongued, not addicted to much wine, not greedy for dishonest gain. They must hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience. And let them also be tested first; then let them serve as deacons if they prove themselves blameless. Their wives likewise must be dignified, not slanderers, but sober-minded, faithful in all things. Let deacons each be the husband of one wife, managing their children and their own households well. For those who serve well as deacons gain a good standing for themselves and also great confidence in the faith that is in Christ Jesus." (1 Timothy 3:8-13)

Who can be appointed into the office of a Deacon or Deaconess?

Potential deacons are to be examined before being appointed: "And let them be tested first, and then let them serve as deacons if they prove themselves blameless" (1 Timothy 3:10).

Only those who meet the character qualities listed in 1 Timothy 3:8-12 may be appointed as deacons. With the notable exception of "able to teach," these qualities parallel that of an elder from 1 Timothy 3:1-7. Deacons must be "dignified, not double-tongued, not addicted to much wine, not greedy for dishonest gain" (v. 8). They also must "hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience" (v. 9), meaning that they understand and live according to the gospel (cf. v. 16). Also, deacons each must be "the husband of one wife, managing their children and their own households well" (v. 12). There are also requirements for their wives, who "must be dignified, not slanderers, but sober-minded, faithful in all things" (v. 11). Those men who have these characteristics, and desire to serve as deacons, are qualified for the office of deacon.

What do Deacons/Deaconesses do?

Deacons perform tasks assigned by another. The meaning of the word "deacon" ("minister"/"servant") implies that they carry out tasks that are assigned by another. Deacons/Deaconesses must always be loyal and obedient to the Assembly Pastors and always willing to take instructions for the day-to-day operations of the Church. They are "servants" of God's house and perform the tasks assigned by the "overseers," who are charged with the leadership of the church.

Deacons perform tasks requiring character, testing, and recognition. Because much of the New Testament teaching on deacons deals with the character requirements of the office, deacons should be assigned tasks requiring maturity and wisdom which would be inappropriate to assign to a novice believer. Similarly, because the New Testament makes clear that deacons are to be tested

and then publicly recognized, it follows that deacons should be entrusted with responsibilities which, if mishandled, would bring reproach upon Christ and his church.

Deacons perform tasks that assist the elders/pastors in the care of the church. Deacons may relieve the elders/pastors of practical tasks so that they can devote themselves to their shepherding responsibilities. They make sure that the Assembly Pastor is not distracted by anything so that he/she can pay more attention to prayer and the ministry of the Word.

Deacons may assist the elders/pastors by handling the church's finances, lead home groups, and disciple young believers, instructing the church in an elder's place or in the absence of the Pastor, coordinating the church's activities, taking care of the needy, the poor and widows, leading church meetings, or communicating to the church body or other churches on behalf of the elders. The elders will assign deacons tasks according to their gifts, desires, and the needs of the church.

Deacons/Deaconesses may carry out specific responsibilities during the Holy Communion Service, Weddings, Anniversaries, Birthdays for Pastors, Baptismal Ceremonies and Funerals.

Spiritual Gifts to Help Deacons/Deaconesses to perform their tasks

Helps or Service: The ability to unselfishly meet the needs of others through practical help. The exercise of this gift often assists a person with a gift of teaching or evangelism and releases them to present the Word of God.

Administration: The ability to organize and manage, working with and through others to achieve goals.

Hospitality: The capacity to provide an open house and graciousness to those in need of food, lodging and fellowship, so that guests are refreshed both physically and spiritually.

Mercy: The capacity to feel sympathy with those in need (especially those who are suffering and miserable), and to manifest this sympathy in some practical way with a cheerful spirit so as to encourage and help those in need.

Removal of Deacons From Office

The procedure for the election of deacons shall be the same as that for the pastor. Deacons are appointed by the Apostle of the Church or by an Assembly Pastor and may also be removed from their office by the Apostle of the Church or by an Assembly Pastor. The term of office for deacon shall be two years with the right of succession with the same vote of the church. Deacons may resign or be asked to resign with 30 days written notice. A candidate for deacon must be an active member of the church in good and regular standing for at least one year before being elected. Deacons shall be overseers of all temporal affairs of the church and upon request may assist the pastor in spiritual affairs. In cases where there is misconduct or neglect of duties the Apostle/Assembly Pastor has the right to discipline erring deacons/deaconesses for the sake of the progress of the Church, this may mean causing the Deacon to step down with immediate effect or partial suspension from active service, pending investigations or in serious offenses, immediate replacement from office.